



The Whispers

The Fool's Court — optional. Sections 9 and 10 of the rules, in full.

22 WORDS · 15 BOONS

7 BURDENS

Leave this leaf in the box and the game is complete without it. Used, the 22 words are shuffled face down each night.

Taking one

After the deal and **before any pledge is made**, each eligible player may look at their own hand and then take one word or go without.

The court does not confide in whoever is winning. Only a player whose favour is *strictly less* than the highest at the table is eligible. On the first night of a season the whole table is level, so nobody is offered a word at all.

Taking one **costs nothing**, but it is taken **unread**: you decide on the strength of your hand alone, not on the word you are about to receive. **7 of the 22 are burdens**, which cost rather than pay, so a word is a gamble rather than a formality.

That a player took one is plain for the table to see; *which* one is not, until the night ends. **The Watched** is the only word that breaks this rule.

What a word does

A Whisper bends how that player's favour is counted, or asks something of the agents they send, or both. Its contents stay **private** until the night ends, when it is revealed alongside the errands.

Some words count **the agent that took the audience for you** — the one that beat the rest. Others count **every agent in an audience you took**, whoever played it. Each card says which.

Three words set your own pledge aside altogether and score the night some other way, so their holder is playing to a different end from everyone else at the table: **Sworn to the Fool, In Another's Pay** and **The Understudy**. The pledge is still kept or broken as a fact, for the sway ladder — it is only the *scoring* of it that is set aside.

Demands

Five words ask something of your errands. **A demand is a request, not a rule.** You

may always pledge exactly as you please and ignore the word entirely.

But a word that was not heeded **pays nothing at all**: its reward is forfeit, and you score the night as though you had gone without one.

WHAT YOU MAY SEND

Blackmailed. At least two Assassins must go out. Keep your pledge for +6.

— *A hand you do not know*

Sworn to Silence. No Assassin may go out. Keep your pledge for +4.

— *The Chapel*

The Smitten. No Lover may go out. Keep your pledge for +5.

— *A Lover*

Sworn to the Ledger. No Merchant may go out. Keep your pledge for +5.

— *The Treasury*

The Audited. Send three Merchants and one Fool, which pledges exactly 2. Keep it for +6.

— *The Treasury*

The rule governing all of these is overleaf. 15 of the 22 words pay; the 7 at the end cost.

HOW YOUR RESULT IS SCORED

The Debtor. A kept pledge of 2 or fewer earns nothing; keep 3 or more for +5.

– The Treasury

All or Nothing. Keep your pledge for double favour. Break it and the night is worth -1 for every audience off it.

– The Court

HOW YOU COMPARE TO THE TABLE

The Bold. +4 if no noble pledges more than you.

– The Monarch

Never in Doubt. Keep your pledge and take +3 for every other noble who broke theirs.

– The Court

The Favourite. +6 if no noble wins more audiences than you.

– The Monarch

The Wallflower. +5 if no noble wins fewer audiences than you.

– A Friend at Court

The Understudy. You are scored against the pledge of the noble on your right, not your own. Take +2 for the trouble, and +5 more if you match it.

– The Court

HOW YOU WIN AUDIENCES

Sworn to the Fool. Your pledge is not scored. +2 for every Fool in the audiences you win.

– The Fool

The Twin. +2 for every pair of agents of the same kind and rank you take in one audience.

– The Monarch

The Modest. +3 for every audience you win with an agent of rank 5 or lower.

– The Monarch

BURDENS

The last 7 are **burdens**, which cost rather than pay. They are framed in oxblood under a **broken seal** and signed as burdens, so there is no mistaking one face up – but every Whisper shares the one back, so a burden cannot be spotted in a rival's hand, and a player who has taken one is under no obligation to say so.

In Another's Pay. ♦ Your pledge is not scored. +5, less 3 for every other noble who keeps theirs.

– A hand you do not know

The Watched. ♦ Your errands are laid face up as soon as they are sent.

– The Chancery

Marked for the Blade. ♦ -2 for every audience an Assassin takes for you.

– One who kills for a living

Out of Favour. ♦ -2 unless no noble wins fewer audiences than you.

– The Monarch

More Was Expected. ♦ -3 for every audience you take short of your pledge.

– The Court

The Beggar's Bargain. ♦ Favour you gain is halved unless you win an audience with a Fool in it.

– A beggar on the steps

Called Out. ♦ -3 if you win more audiences than the noble on your right.

– A rival noble

Asking the court for their secrets is always a gamble – a player who is behind needs it, and the court refuses one to whoever is ahead.